

Gender and Personal Pronouns: She, He, It and They

Personal pronouns appear to indicate who or what acts in the world by standing in for people and things: '*she* kicked the ball', '*he* cooked dinner', '*it* sank', '*they* got married'. Personal pronouns sometimes, but not always, include the 'gender' of the person or object involved. This chapter will analyse what it means to talk of language as 'gendered', and the implications this has for thinking, and living, in the world.

It has become generally accepted within sociology and social theory that it is possible to make a distinction between 'sex' and 'gender'. The term 'sex' refers to the biological or anatomical characteristics of individual humans, usually in terms of their reproductive organs or capacity to procreate. In this sense, 'sex' becomes shorthand for the 'sexual difference' between men and women. This realm is in the purview of science, especially medical science, which seeks to demarcate the biological characteristics of 'man' and 'woman'. Social and cultural scientists, on the other hand, have tended to deal with what they refer to as 'gender'. Anthropologists such as Mead (1949) have described the divergent ways in which different societies or cultures have treated those individuals whom they deem to be 'men' or 'women'. Feminists have used 'sex' and gender to drive a conceptual wedge between the biological and the societal approaches, for example by pointing to the important distinction to be made between two sets of adjectives: 'male' and 'female' and 'masculine' and 'feminine'. These pairs invoke, respectively, the realms of 'sex' and 'gender'. In this argument, it is maintained that variances in attitudes and expectations with regard to gender

are not caused by biological factors. If this were the case, there would be no differences between societies and cultures in how they think and act towards men and women, as the same cause would always have the same or similar effect. Also, understandings of what constitutes appropriate gender roles would not have changed over time, if gender were not related to society rather than biology. The task of social and cultural sciences is to map, and perhaps alter, attitudes to what is expected or acceptable in terms of gender and gender roles.

The 'correct' terminology for those individuals who do not fit within the rather static categories of 'man' and 'woman', 'male' and 'female' or 'masculine' and 'feminine' is contested (Whittle 2006) and has recently shifted away from the more medical term 'transsexual' to 'transgender' or 'trans'. Towards the end of this chapter, I will return to such considerations. Before this, it is necessary to investigate the question of gender more closely in terms of a range of questions, such as: What does it mean to talk of gender with regard to language? When we talk of gender in language ('she', 'he') do we mean 'sex' or 'gender'? Is language 'sexed', suggesting that it has some relation to the male or female, or is it 'gendered', suggesting that it is an entirely 'social' affair?

Writing in 1926, in his influential book *A Dictionary of Modern English Usage*, H. W. Fowler provides one answer to such questions, when he states that gender 'is a grammatical term only. To talk of *persons or creatures of the masculine or feminine g[ender]*, meaning of the male or female sex is either a jocularity (permissible or not according to context) or a blunder' (Fowler 1937: 211). Fowler is drawing on the original Latin meaning of the word *genus* from which the modern word gender is derived. *Genus* indicates a 'type' or 'kind', and is related to the word 'genre'. In this sense, grammatical gender simply indicates a genre, a kind or category into which words are placed. It is entirely social; it refers to the human element of language alone, and the world, once again, does not present itself as it is. Rather, the world is organised according to arbitrary (human) categories, in this case, that of gender, into which different words such as nouns and

pronouns are sifted and sorted. To ask if such genders, genres or categories are, of themselves, biologically 'sexed' is, for Fowler, a mistake, even a joke. In those languages which refer to the sun in 'masculine' terms and the moon in the 'feminine', it is not that these two objects are in themselves male or female. It is simply a matter of a human placement of differing categories upon a world that is resolutely unconcerned and uninvolved in such classifications. To believe that language is gendered, in the sense of being 'sexed', is to misunderstand the status of grammar.

Fowler's suggestion would seem to be that other words could have been adopted for these classifications. Perhaps nouns might be categorised in terms of 'up', 'down' and 'middle', instead of 'masculine', 'feminine' and 'neuter'. The sun might be of the 'up' gender, the moon of the 'down' gender, while those items currently described as neuter would be ascribed to the 'middle' gender. This raises the question of why the specific terms 'masculine', 'feminine' and 'neuter' were chosen to divide up language and the world. There is the secondary question, of whether even if 'up', 'down' and 'middle' had been selected, would there not be some kind of hierarchy between these (where 'up' is taken to be better than 'down')? These words have meanings and connotations that carve up both language and the world in a very particular way.

Rethinking 'Sex' and Gender

Although many sociologists ascribe the establishment of the distinction between 'sex' and gender to Simone de Beauvoir in her 1949 text *The Second Sex*, this division is not as clear-cut in de Beauvoir's work as is sometimes thought to be the case. This is not to suggest that making a distinction between 'sex' and gender is wrong, but it does need to be approached with care.

In the Introduction to the first volume of *The Second Sex*, de Beauvoir states that her main aim is to ask (and respond to) the question: 'What is a woman?' (de Beauvoir 1988: 13). In the

Introduction to the second volume, she writes: ‘When I use the words *woman* or *feminine* I obviously refer to no archetype, no changeless essence’ (de Beauvoir 1988: 31, emphasis in original). De Beauvoir argues that the question of the existence, and the experience of the existence, of ‘woman’ has not previously been addressed. There is a lack of thought about *both* the status of ‘woman’ and the lives of women. However, de Beauvoir does not make a strict division between these two elements. She does not reduce the question of what a woman ‘is’ to the biological (‘sex’); likewise, the lived societal experience of women (‘gender’) is not purely social. To immediately separate off the anatomical from the societal or cultural leads to the creation of two worlds: the natural and the social. ‘Sex’, in the sense of sexual difference, would fall under the remit of biology, of the natural. Gender would be located in the realm of the social, to be studied by sociology and cultural studies. This produces another bifurcation, a powerful and insidious one. In this instance the sexed body is placed in the real world, while gender only exists in the words and language deployed to conceptualise, and to talk of, this other world. Once again, words and things have been divided; on this occasion the gulf pivots around questions of biological sexual difference and gender.

This is not the position that de Beauvoir develops, even though traces of this apparently straightforward split resonate throughout many subsequent sociological readings of ‘sex’ and gender. De Beauvoir’s stance provides a more complex account in which it is not always clear where the body ends and society begins. De Beauvoir is, however, very precise in her melding, and this leads her to an important perspective on the interrelations of language and the world, of words and things.

A man would never set out to write a book on the peculiar situation of the human male. But if I wish to define myself, I must first of all say: ‘I am a woman’ [. . .] A man never begins by presenting himself as an individual of a certain sex; it goes without saying that he is a man. The terms *masculine* and *feminine* are used symmetrically only as a matter of form, as on legal

papers. In actuality the relation of the two sexes is not quite like that of two electrical poles, for man represents both the positive and the neutral [. . .] whereas woman represents only the negative. (de Beauvoir 1988: 15, emphasis in original)

Men take their status as both humans and as men for granted. For example, men do not have to explain that they are writing 'as a man'. It is seen as normal, as 'natural' even. The fact that the writer is male has no bearing on what he is writing, so it is not even worth mentioning. Women do not share this privilege; they are immediately seen as 'women writers'. Their thoughts and writings do not come out of nowhere (as appears to be the case for men); they are not pure and objective (as male writers might claim for themselves); they always come from somewhere. This somewhere is tied up, somehow, with them being women, which, in turn, appears to refer to the biological. They are *women* writers.

De Beauvoir's analysis invokes the terms 'masculine' and 'feminine', and, as has been seen, these have often been taken to refer to the gendered element of the argument. This involves a description of a particular kind of society, one in which such terms are used in legal documents, for example. Yet masculine and feminine are not opposites with equal weight, as is the case with the plus and minus associated with positive and negative electrical charges. De Beauvoir is relying upon a factor in the French language which is not, at first sight, as evident in English. It also links to the subject matter of this chapter, as set out in its title, namely, personal pronouns.

The French for 'he' is *il*. Yet the same term is used even when the gender of the thing or person in question is not known. All nouns are gendered in French and, in the case of a dog, the noun is masculine (*le chien*). There is also a French word for a 'female' dog, namely, *la chienne*. However, this word would only be used if the speaker had the extra knowledge that the dog were female; it is not something that is assumed. When asking if someone has a dog, the masculine form would be used, as this is assumed to be the normal situation. The female dog is an exception.

De Beauvoir's point is reinforced by the fact that this also applies when there is no apparent noun (or subject); for example, when commenting on an apparently neutral state of affairs such as 'it is warm' or 'it is raining'. In both cases, the masculine form *il* would be used to stand in for 'it' (*il fait chaud, il pleut*). The masculine element incorporates both those things that are known to be male (men and dogs) and also those situations where the gender is not known, or is deemed irrelevant. There is an imbalance between the masculine and the feminine; they are not reflections of each other. Worse, the masculine becomes the default position, the norm, while the feminine is only used to indicate those peculiar, uncommon occurrences where women, the female or the feminine are involved. It is this peculiarity that, according to de Beauvoir, makes it possible to describe the feminine as representing the unusual, the exception, as that which deviates from the norm. De Beauvoir suggests that this entails that the female and the feminine is regarded as an aberration.

This difficulty is particularly acute when it comes to the personal pronoun word 'they' (the third person plural). In French, if all members of the group are male the word *ils* is used; if they are all female, then *elles* is used. A problem arises when the group is mixed. There is no word in French that indicates the mix of the masculine and feminine or men and women, in a group; instead, the long-standing rule is to deploy the masculine plural, *ils*. The feminine is subsumed into the masculine. This imbalance is not just evident in French but in a range of European languages, and probably beyond. Furthermore, in many languages (especially certain Slavic ones) it applies not only to 'he', 'she', 'they' and 'it' but to possessive pronouns and verbs. The Czech writer Jindra Tichý has pointed out the absurdity of the situation with regard to verbs through the consideration of two apparently very similar sentences:¹

1. Tichý's article is available at <http://nb.vse.cz/kfil/elogos/logpoint/94-3/NTICHA.htm> (accessed 22 July 2019).

All the women of the world went for a walk.

In Czech this would read:

Všechny ženy světa šly na procházku.

Tichý presents a second sentence:

John and all the women of the world went for a walk.

In Czech this would read:

John a všechny ženy světa šel na procházku.

The difference lies in the change of the past tense of the verb 'to go' (*jít*).² In the situation involving 'only' all the women of the world, the feminine form of the verb in the plural is used (*šly*). However, when *one* man tags along with all the women of the world, the verb has to change to reflect the presence of this one man, and so the masculine form of the verb is used (*šel*). Tichý points out that it only takes one man to be present for the activity of all the women of the world to be incorporated into the masculine form.

These examples demonstrate how widespread and influential are the problems of gender in terms of 'sex', in both language and the world, remembering that language is part of the world. Problems with inequality in language are also problems in the world. These discrepancies lurk in our thought, language and lives. As the francophone Belgian philosopher Luce Irigaray puts it:

we argue and debate within a field and with logical and grammatical tools defined in such a way that we cannot really think. The horizon of understanding we have debars us from that thought. We discuss, we reason, but we do not think. (Irigaray 1996: 36)

2. The verb 'to go' (*jít*) is irregular in Czech, hence the different form of the past participle, namely, *šel*.

Grammar, logic and the world hinder us in our thinking. For Irigaray, grammar is based on a difference between the sexes that is unrealistic, as it does not see male and female (or masculine and feminine) as either equals or as different and yet, if not equal, then at least having their own integrity. Grammar does not grant a positive content to both of the terms ‘masculine’ and ‘feminine’. Instead, the latter is viewed as an insipid reflection of the former and can be subsumed into it. Our grammar prioritises the male and sometimes hides behind a supposedly neutral (or neuter) term to disguise this. This has consequences not just for our words, thought and language but for the world.

Like de Beauvoir, Irigaray argues that the concept of ‘woman’ and the lived experience of women have not been given sufficient conceptual exploration or status in the world. Irigaray is explicit in her refusal of any simple division between ‘sex’ and gender when addressing such concerns.

Given the way that our society is structured – men were, when young, totally dependent on women. They use them for succour and support to become what they are. Then leave them out of public life. This is more than just gender. This is how the world is (ontologically). (Irigaray 1993: 78)

As Whitford (1991) makes clear, when reading (or translating) both de Beauvoir and Irigaray, attention needs to be paid to the specific meanings of the words that they use; for example *sexe*, *féminin*, *genre*.³ These might seem to map on to the English words ‘sex’, ‘feminine’ and ‘gender’. But they do not. *Sexe* can refer to genitals, but it also has a wider scope and can overlap with some elements of the English term ‘gender’. *Féminin* can be translated as either feminine or female, and it is not always clear, except from context, whether reference is being made to the supposedly ‘natural’ or ‘societal’ element. *Genre* does not immediately or only mean ‘gender’. It encompasses the original

3. Margaret Whitford has provided a very helpful glossary of these and other terms in her collection of essays by Irigaray (see Whitford 1991).

Latin sense of ‘type’ or ‘kind’, as discussed earlier. Importantly, in French, *genre* can also refer to grammatical gender. Such intricacies are important when considering the abiding problem of whether language is ‘sexed’ or gendered and how this relates to the real people of the world. This has been an enduring concern of Irigaray for over forty years, from a rereading of the philosophical, scientific and psychoanalytic canon of Western thought to contemporary politics (Irigaray 1985a; 1985b; 1993; 1994; 1996; 2000a; 2000b).

Job Titles

With regard to language and the world, lives and grammar, Irigaray gives the example of how, in both French and English syntax, an occupation is often regarded as a kind of possession (as discussed in the previous chapter, Dewey would also question the metaphysical accuracy of such an approach). Grammatically speaking, it can seem as if the subject (the ‘I’) possesses an object (the occupation) – ‘I *have* a job as a baker.’ Irigaray argues that maleness is, surreptitiously perhaps, expressed in this situation. Not only, practically and historically speaking, have most occupations tended to be held by men (butchers, bakers and candlestick-makers) but, as with de Beauvoir, the normal and the neutral have been regarded as male. The female is only remarked upon as accidental or unusual. This is more evident in French where the person who has the occupation is usually referred to as male, while the field or area in which a person works (the occupation itself) is taken to be female. The default noun for a doctor (*le médecin*) takes the masculine form while the realm of medicine (*la médecine*) takes the feminine (Irigaray 1993: 128). Irigaray points to other, almost paradoxical, situations. For example, in French it is possible to hold the occupation of café-owner (*un cafétier*). However, to be a specifically female café-owner would be to be *une cafetière*, which, in both English and French, means coffee-pot. The specifically female café-owner

is an impossibility, as the word is already taken by a different ‘feminine’ object – a coffee-pot (Irigaray 1994: 50), something which can be possessed but cannot be lived. Irigaray thinks that this is a serious problem not only because it means that language is unbalanced but because this instantiates a genuine imbalance in the world.

At this stage of the discussion, however, the objection might be raised that Irigaray’s (and perhaps de Beauvoir’s) analysis might have some force when analysing Francophone societies, but it has limited relevance to the Anglophone world. There are two possible responses to such claims. The second, which will be dealt with below, involves Irigaray’s arguments regarding the status of ‘sexed’ human subjects (‘man’ and ‘woman’). A first response can be found in a consideration of personal pronouns.

Gendered English

The use of personal pronouns, such as ‘he’, ‘she’, ‘it’ and ‘they’, in English, has changed over time. For example, in the previous chapter, quotations were offered from John Dewey that included the following phrases: ‘houses are usually owned, are mine and yours and *his*’. The assumption seems to be that women do not own houses. Elsewhere Dewey writes: ‘Nature is kind and hateful, bland and morose, irritating and comforting, long before *she* is mathematically qualified.’ These are occasions when gender is used in English. Nature is female, it is claimed, because ‘she’ is to do with reproduction, regeneration. This is compounded by the related idea that such nature is studied by ‘*men* of science’, as Whitehead unfortunately puts it (Whitehead 1964: 29). Of course, Dewey and Whitehead were writing in a different era. Things have changed. A danger, however, lies in assuming that there is some smooth trajectory towards equality that somehow plays out through the unfolding of reason, so that various societies become more aware of the reasonableness of countering gender inequality in the world and in the way that we talk about

the world. Nevertheless, the very fact that the use of personal pronouns has changed demonstrates that their meaning and usage is not fixed; it is something that can be contested. Such contestations have a history which is, in itself, informative.

Returning to H. W. Fowler, in his *Dictionary of Modern English Usage*, he states:

Everyone knows the inconvenience of being uncertain whether a doctor is a man or a woman; hesitation in establishing the word *doctress* is amazing. Far from needing to reduce the number of our sex-words, we should do well to indulge in real neologisms such as *teacheress*, *singeress* and *danceress*. (Fowler, cited in Marsh 2014: 232)

The multiplying of terms for women performing certain occupations or roles might appear quaint, if not ridiculous. Writing ‘as a man’, as de Beauvoir might put it, Fowler’s initial concern, presumably, is that he might be embarrassed when having to be treated by a medical doctor who happens to be a woman. Yet it may well be the case that certain people, on certain occasions, would prefer to see a doctor of the same ‘sex’ or gender. I will consider this point in more detail after a brief detour through the world of actors and actresses.

David Marsh, while in the role of production editor of *The Guardian* newspaper, insisted that journalists should never use the word ‘actress’ but only that of ‘actor’.⁴ One reason for this is that the word ‘actress’ is seen as limiting. In a theatre company, to describe a person as the best actress is to compare them to the other female actors in the group. To call someone the best actor

4. Marsh uses the rather ‘local’ example of the British cast of the series of *Carry On* films to make his point. ‘If I describe Hattie Jacques as the finest actress in the *Carry On* films, I am judging her against the likes of Joan Sims, Barbara Windsor and (the criminally underrated) Patsy Rowlands. If I declare her to be the finest *Carry On* actor, I am saying Hattie’s body of work was not just better than the other women’s, but superior to those of Kenneth Williams, Sidney James and Charles Hawtrey as well’ (Marsh 2014: 231).

is not simply to state that they are the best male actor, but that they are the best at acting in the company. The female has been subsumed into the male, in a manner akin to that described by de Beauvoir and Irigaray. The masculine term (actor) can include the female, but not the other way around. If both words are in current usage, then there is an asymmetry between 'actor' and 'actress'. Actor also stands in for the neuter (where the gender of the person acting is not known), so the balance is skewed. Given that those individuals working in the theatre and cinema are performing comparable roles, the argument is that they should all be called 'actors' (and paid equally for equal work).

This seems like a cogent argument, and it echoes the thoughts of de Beauvoir on the asymmetry inherent in language and the world. However, it is important to be aware of its limitations and consequences. The specific history of our society and our language is one in which most occupations, such as that of doctor, teacher and actor, were carried out by men. Women, and the female version, were rare, even peculiar. They needed further explanation (hence Fowler's demand for 'doctresses'). Apparently neutral words, such as actor, provide a yardstick that may not immediately appear to refer to the male, or to be masculine; but in so far as women are not immediately seen as fully representative of the weight of these words, then language is indeed sexed or gendered since it tends to favour the male or masculine aspect. Insisting immediately upon a general imposition of one singular term may pay lip-service to the problem of language and gender, but may also ignore the more fundamental problem.

This leads Irigaray to suggest that there is a need to develop and express specific female (or feminine) subject positions. Paradoxically (for some), this means that she outlines a position that is not so dissimilar from that of Fowler when he advocated the proliferation of titles for female holders of certain occupations. The concern, for Irigaray, is that recognition of the specific contribution or approach of women in and to the world is in danger of being reduced or subsumed by their being incorporated within a male (or masculine) term. To avoid this, the female

aspect needs to be given its due, with its own words and terms, and not swept under the masculine conceptual carpet. The spirit in which Irigaray makes her argument is radically different from that of Fowler. 'I suggest that the following law be passed: The mixed plural will be masculine [*ils*] one year; feminine [*elles*] the next' (Irigaray 1994: 49). It is important, however, to recognise that this would only constitute one very small step. To think that the problems lie in language alone, and that, if language were correctly policed, the inequalities of the world would somehow disappear, is to be disingenuous at best. According to Irigaray, the task is to change the world-as-it-is-now so that it is possible to become full human subjects.

Sexual difference cannot [. . .] be reduced to a simple extra-linguistic fact of nature. It conditions language and is conditioned by it. It not only determines the system of pronouns, possessive adjectives, but also the gender of words [. . .] It's situated at the junction of nature and culture. (Irigaray 1993: 20)

Sexual difference is not a fact of nature, separate from language. Sexual difference does not simply determine language, but nor is language separate from the actuality of sexual difference. Irigaray is pointing towards the complexity of the interrelations of language and the world, of words and things. As Irigaray makes clear, our real bodies and our actual words come together to make the world-as-it-is-now. This is not dissimilar from the ideas of Whitehead, Deleuze and Dewey, as discussed in previous chapters. The added layer is that some of these 'things' are what we think of, and speak of, as human subjects.

Some have taken issue with Irigaray and her insistence that the primary fact of sexual difference is the difference between men and women, or between man and woman; for example when she writes: 'a double nature exists, a masculine and a feminine nature' (Irigaray 2000a: 47). Irigaray places great emphasis on the need to develop relations between these two: 'We are all of us, men and women alike, sexed. Our principal task is to make

the transition from nature to culture as sexed beings, to become women and men while remaining faithful to our gender' (Irigaray 1996: 30). For many commentators, this means that Irigaray not only assumes that the most fundamental couple is a heterosexual one, thereby relegating homosexual relations to a secondary position, but she completely overlooks the status of intersexed and transgender individuals. Such criticisms certainly have some weight and it is not my intention to completely defend Irigaray. The reliance upon the relations between 'man and woman' as foundational is troublesome.

At the same time, Irigaray's work helps to develop a way of taking the relations between language, bodies and the world seriously. Language and our bodies are not separate as 'language [. . .] is made flesh in you, in me, in us' (Irigaray 2000b: 19). Moreover, Irigaray clarifies that altering language alone is not enough; it is always a matter of language and the world, and the complex relations between the two. For the arguments being set out in this book, Irigaray's importance lies in her utter refusal of the bifurcation of either 'sex' and 'gender' or nature and culture. In this way, she follows and extends Whitehead's protest against the implicit and unwarranted fault-line of modern thought which separates, or bifurcates, the real from experiences of the real, things from their properties, the world from language. Avoiding such separations is no easy task, and Irigaray's alternative might not be wholly successful. Yet she is resolute in facing up to the difficulties involved in such a project. One example of this is the insistence that matters of 'sex', 'gender' and language do not lie in the realm of either nature or culture. What is required is a rethinking of this apparent dichotomy. Irigaray does not want to erase or deconstruct the concepts of man and woman but to rethink them, retaining elements of what is supposedly captured by the terms 'sex' and 'gender'. She attempts this by deploying the term 'sexuate': 'I am sexuate, I am not neuter, anonymous or interchangeable' (Irigaray 2000b: 39). And: 'I am asking to be recognized as really an other, irreducible to the masculine subject' (Irigaray 2000a: 124). Her protest, as discussed

previously, is against the subsumption of the female aspect into the male or masculine, for example through the unthinking use of neutral terms which, in fact, are biased towards the male. To achieve this, Irigaray sets out to develop a model of female subjectivity that is different from, and not reducible to, the model of subjectivity that has, until now, been taken as universal, when it is, she argues, only partial, only masculine.

Irigaray maintains that predominant conceptions of what it means to be a (human) subject, an 'I', have been characterised, both in thought and speech, on a model of the male (or *masculin*). This has involved treating women and the word 'woman' as secondary. Irigaray's tracing of the wide-ranging, but often unnoticed, ways in which subjectivity has been characterised as male or masculine is sustained, powerful and complex, and it is not possible to do justice to it here (for a fuller reading, see Halewood 2011a: 125–46; Stone 2006; Whitford 1991). The previous chapter outlined Whitehead's insistence on the centrality of the 'withness' of the body, both to existence and thought. Irigaray characterises the traditional model of Western philosophy and science in similar terms, for example, in the lack and denigration of the role of the body as is to be found in Plato:

Blind except for the contemplation of his Ideas. *Deaf* except to the sounds of his soul revolving in harmony, and the soul speaks only to itself without the aid or assistance of any voice. Thought now capable of doing without 'discourse' or 'dialogue' [. . .] *Without hands or feet*, organs, unfitted to the movements of intelligence and reflection [. . .] *Taking care not to touch* any 'strange things,' also, and *deprived of legs* so that there can be no walking off toward something attractive outside the self. Completeness of one who is self-sufficient: this is the destiny to which the souls are called who have donned the nature of the living beings most able to honor the Gods. (Irigaray 1985a: 321, emphasis in original)

The masculine bias of philosophy is expressed in a 'withoutness' of the body. The task, which resonates with Whitehead's

approach, is to develop a philosophy that can incorporate the 'witness' of the body and deal with the implications of recognising bodilyness as a crucial and enduring factor in existence and our lives.

A crucial and distinct element of Irigaray's thought is the appeal to develop ways of thinking and speaking that start from the position of women and woman. What is (again) controversial in Irigaray's argument is that, in order to do this, it is necessary to start from the status of women's bodies. Western thought and language have started from a supposition of that which constitutes the male body: 'the fundamental model of the human being [. . .] one, singular, solitary and historically masculine, that of the adult Western male, rational and competent' (Irigaray 2000a: 122). The male (or masculine) subject has been taken as singular and complete. Irigaray argues that, in order to challenge this, it is necessary for women to start thinking, talking and acting in a way that avoids this singularity, as epitomised by the male body. The starting point that she advocates is the specific status of women's bodies. The advantage of this is summed up in the title of one of Irigaray's most important books – *This Sex Which Is Not One*. Irigaray believes that women's bodies are not reducible or explainable in terms of the unity that men claim for themselves or for their language. Men have one penis. Women's sex organs are not unitary: 'She has at least two of them, but they are not identifiable as ones. Indeed she has many more. Her sexuality, always at least double, goes even further, it is *plural*' (Irigaray 1985b: 28, emphasis in original).

The problem, for some feminists, is that this seems to put us back into the realm of the 'natural' body. This runs the risk of returning to a position where men and women have radically different biological make-ups, which lead them to think and behave in different ways (men are built to be hunters, to be aggressive: women are built to bear children, to be caring). This is exactly what the distinction between sex and gender was meant to help overcome. However, Irigaray thinks that this distinction can itself be problematic and limiting.

The difficulties women have in gaining recognition for their social and political rights are rooted in this insufficiently thought out relation between biology and culture. At present, to deny all explanations of a biological kind – because biology has paradoxically been used to exploit women – is to deny the key to interpreting this exploitation. (Irigaray 1993: 46)

Taken in the light of Whitehead's critique of the bifurcation of nature, this can be read in a way that does not resort to biological essentialism but, rather, recognises that an easy separation of nature from culture is an expression of a deeper problem, one that is to do with some of the complexities of thinking about the relation of language and the world, as set out in previous chapters.

Irigaray focuses on one specific iteration of these relations, namely whether the things of the world, including human subjects, are sexed or gendered, and how language is implicated in this, or even limits thought. The importance of Irigaray lies in the insistence that any attempt to simply erase or efface current inequalities between men and women, or between the genders, by adopting supposedly neutral terms, is to misunderstand the problem. Tinkering with language to avoid or remove words or phrases that are considered inappropriate or offensive is not enough. What is required is a change in thinking, speaking and being; this will involve changing the world.

Telling Others What to Say, and Think

The question of whether it is worthwhile or valid to remark upon and criticise how others speak is a contentious issue. For some, grammar is purely descriptive; the task for linguistics is only to outline the syntax and semantics that people use. If those living in twenty-first-century Britain choose to use the word 'literally' to mean 'figuratively', then so be it. On the other hand, there are those who believe that grammar, syntax and semantics form an ordered system with its own logic and rules.

These need to be regulated and reinforced, with ‘errors’ being corrected. This is the prescriptive approach. It is important to note, however, that discussions that are often held to be about grammar are not actually to do with the grammatical structure of a language. For example, the changing meaning of a word, such as ‘literally’, is concerned with semantics rather than grammatical structure. Strictly speaking, grammarians would limit themselves to instances such as the assertion that it is forbidden to ever split an infinitive, or to split an infinitive, ever. Most ‘liberal-minded’ writers tend towards seeing grammar as descriptive and believe prescriptive grammarians to be outdated and doomed in their misguided attempts to apply the rules and rigours that often derive from a dead language, Latin, to the living, breathing phenomenon that is English today.

One current example is the personal pronoun ‘they’, with its related possessive pronoun ‘their’. It is generally accepted that it is a mistake to use a plural to refer to a singular. However, when it comes to describing an individual whose ‘sex’ or ‘gender’ is not known, this raises a problem. On hearing unexpected footsteps in one’s house, a person might comment – ‘There is someone coming up the stairs.’ But what if I am worried that the person is a burglar? Should I say – ‘I wonder if they [the ‘someone’] have come to rob us?’ This is technically incorrect, according to some grammarians; the plural ‘they’ has been used when only one set of footsteps was heard, and the individual pronoun, ‘someone’, has been used previously. As a result, the singular, either ‘he’ or ‘she’, should have been used. Would it be better to say ‘I wonder if he has come to rob us?’ or ‘I wonder if she has come to rob us?’ It may well be that most burglars in the UK are male, but does that warrant jumping to a linguistic conclusion? Most burglars are under 35. Would this justify saying ‘I wonder if that male under 35 has come to rob us?’ This may seem like an abstruse example, but the reach of the question is more widespread than might first be thought.

The dichotomy between ‘he’ and ‘she’ does not reflect the range of possible experiences of people in the world. Writers

such as Whittle (2006) point out that personal pronouns are limiting and exclusionary for some of those who identify as ‘trans’ and who do not want to be reduced, necessarily, either to ‘he’ or ‘she’, sometimes preferring the word ‘they’ or neologisms (such as ‘per’) to be used as the relevant pronoun. What is noticeable in such arguments is that this involves a prescriptive approach to grammar; it requires ‘telling’ people what words to use, or not use. Yet the prescriptive approach, that of enforcing rules, has long been associated with a conservative view that looks backward to a logic in the English language that needs to be preserved. In the case of the personal pronoun ‘they’, such concerns can be partially assuaged by the examples from Lewis Carroll, Shakespeare, the Authorised Version of the Bible and Thackeray that Marsh (2014: 229–30) cites, to demonstrate that the practice of using this term to refer to individuals has a long history.

Nevertheless, the idea that language should be ‘policed’ is not wedded to either a conservative or a more liberal viewpoint. As has been seen, Irigaray, and other feminists such as Spender (1980), insist that language needs to be altered, as does the world. Resistance to such prescriptive changes can come from those who argue *against* what has been called ‘political correctness’, citing instances such as the ‘banning’ of the word ‘chairman’ to refer to the person who runs a committee, irrespective of their ‘sex’ or gender. This is an instructive example. In most universities in the UK, it is common to call the person who is taking a meeting the ‘chair’, rather than ‘chairman’ or ‘chairwoman’. The chair has the responsibility and the right to set the agenda, guide discussion, and to help inform decisions. The chair has a certain authority. This raises the question of what kind of authority is held by the chair. As is often the case, the history of the word, and the worlds in which that word have operated, are informative.

The word ‘chair’ is ultimately derived from the Latin term *cathedra*, as in the related English word ‘cathedral’. Indeed, there is an overlap between the two terms. A cathedral marks the place where the power and authority of a bishop resides; it also indicates the area over which the bishop can exercise their

authority, their diocese. A diocese can also be referred to as a 'see', which itself is derived from the Latin for seat (*sedes*). Chairs and seats are tied up with the authority of the Christian Church. In fact, there really are (or were) chairs in cathedrals from which bishops speak. The actual chair from which pronouncements are made encapsulates the authority of the Church, enabling what is said to hold weight, truth and power. Moreover, this kind of authority has been resolutely male, for at least two reasons. First, all bishops (until recently) have been men. Second, the kind of authority exercised by the Christian Church represents a model of power, located in a central authority (the chair), which is associated with how masculinity has been understood in the West. Bishops represent a kind of masculine authority and the authority of a bishop's chair reinforces a specific kind of masculinity.

This is not only of theological interest. Professors at universities are still called 'chairs' in their official titles. Stephen Hawking held the Lucasian Chair in Mathematics at the University of Cambridge, which was founded in 1663 by Henry Lucas. This chair was also held by Isaac Newton. It is not an overstatement to assert that it is the chair that makes someone a professor. As was the case with bishops, there used to be actual chairs in which professors sat, although this is rarely the situation today. Such chairs grant an authority that is analogous to that of a bishop. Indeed, this is its derivation, in that Western universities were originally institutions within the Christian Church, designed to further theological knowledge and train *men* for their roles in the Church. The cloisters and quadrangles at older universities such as Oxford and Cambridge, with their similarities to monastery buildings, are reminders of this. Nowadays, the domain (or diocese) within which a professor has authority is often still made explicit in their full title: Professor of Ancient History, Professor of Modern Social Theory, etc. The form of professorial authority still bears the traces of its origin and enables a professor to profess, to state their own ideas with authority; an authority that is ultimately derived from their chair. In one important

sense, the authority held by professors is male *and* masculine. It is derived from that of bishops; most professors have been (and still are) men; the kind of authority incorporated in a professorship models a traditional view of masculinity (professors do not like being contradicted).

This is why questions as to whether to say ‘chairman’, ‘chair-woman’ or simply ‘chair’ are not only to do with language. They are tied up with our history, our world as it was and as it is now. As a result, it might well be better to talk of actors and chairs rather than to invent female versions of these words. However, this is not the whole answer, for, as we have seen, the words and things (the people and their chairs) are implicated within a form of authority that is closely tied to our understandings of what it means to be a man and a woman. It is necessary to recognise the specificity of the model of (masculine) authority implicated in the chairs of bishops, professors and committees. This mention of specificity is important. As Donna Haraway, in a slightly different context, puts it: ‘all dreams for a perfectly true language, of perfectly naming experience [. . .] are totalizing and imperialist’ (1991: 173). To treat language as a system, dislocated from the world, or from worlds with their particular histories, and to claim that language can be cleansed or purified, separately from its specific legacies, would be both to bifurcate language from the world and attempt to impose abstract answers on to concrete problems.⁵ Each instance needs to be dealt with on its own merits, and language is not to be separated from the world that enables it to express and be expressed.

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5. As has been argued throughout this chapter, even within the English language the question of gender is involved more often than might be first thought. For example, when I originally wrote the previous sentence, I used the phrase ‘is to be naïve at best’. Perhaps because my mind is focused on issues of grammar and gender, I became uneasy about the word ‘naïve’ and checked its origin. It comes from the French *naïf*. This is the masculine version, but in English the feminine form ‘naïve’ has been adopted. Although not immediately obvious, to be naïve is, in some way, linked with the feminine. This is reinforced by the retention, in English, of

Conclusion

Building on ideas developed throughout this book, this chapter has argued that questions and problems involving words and things take on a new slant when the matter of concern becomes human individuals and how to refer to them, through personal pronouns for example. It has been argued that avoiding gendered constructions might appear to reduce the ‘gender problem’ in English, but that is actually to remain at the level of language alone. The things of the world have dropped out of the picture. In this case, these things are actual, individual humans – men, women and those who identify as neither. Reducing references to gender is not necessarily an advantage; it might suggest an erasure of women from the scene of writing and speaking, by making this scene entirely neuter, and therefore, following de Beauvoir and Irigaray, resolutely male. To put it bluntly, and invoking another set of ideas, it is certainly possible for politicians, police officers or journalists to learn to talk about ‘ethnic communities’ rather than about ‘coloureds’, ‘Asians’ or worse. But this does not mean that the way they think and act in the world has changed.

Returning to the question of ‘sex’ and ‘gender’, the extent to which these are concepts or ‘things’ that permeate the world and language is still unclear. The work of Irigaray is useful in pointing to the complex relations between language and different forms of subjectivity. However, Irigaray’s analysis relies on the difference between ‘masculine’ and ‘feminine’ as being foundational, and this aspect needs reorienting. Remaining faithful to the idea that language is an element of the world and that the world is not fixed makes it possible to consider how human bodies come to be. This does not necessarily entail starting with the notions of

the masculine version ‘naïf’, even if it is rarely used. When searching for an alternative word, I considered ‘disingenuous’, which is equally problematic in that it is again derived from a feminine form of a French word – *ingénue*. In both English and French this refers to an inexperienced girl or young woman.

‘man’ and ‘woman’. Rather, man and woman are outcomes, and they are not the only possible outcomes. The processes that go into creating such outcomes involve both language and material bodies. We become actual men, women, trans, indeed more or otherwise, on different occasions and in different ways. The role of the adverbial comes to the fore once again. The processes involved are neither ‘natural’ nor ‘social’. Language and the world become together; in doing so, they express those elements that later come to be called natural and social. The perspective needs to be shifted. The natural and social, ‘sex’ and gender, are not generative but are themselves things that come to be. Man and woman are not ideas or entities that exist continually. They come to be at different points and different times. This is something that Irigaray acknowledges in part, though only within the limits of a firm distinction between man and woman. For example: ‘each man must remain a man in the process of becoming. He himself has to accomplish the task of being *this* man he is by birth and a model of humanity, a model that is both corporeal and spiritual’ (Irigaray 1996: 27, emphasis in original). Such processes are, according to Irigaray, more ‘straightforward’ than those involving woman: ‘puberty, loss of virginity, maternity, menopause, – stages requiring a more complex becoming than that of man’ (Irigaray 2000a: 131).

It would, however, be necessary to extend Irigaray’s analysis so that other ways of coming-to-be were recognised and made possible. Other kinds of bodies can become; transgendered and intersexed, for example. This would also apply to questions of sexuality, so that an individual’s sexuality is no longer envisaged as fixed. It is not a question of whether sexual inclinations are innate or culturally acquired. Such an approach would again be to indulge in a primary bifurcation. We become straight, gay, lesbian or otherwise over and over again, at different points and in different ways. This is an important point that has implications for debates between some feminists and some trans activists over whether someone who identifies as a different gender to that which was ascribed to them at birth is, for example, a ‘real’

woman. The reading of Whitehead offered throughout this book would suggest that there is a need to shift the way in which such debates are set up. It might be better to move beyond any assumption of the fixity of the concept of man or woman to a recognition of the complex processes that go into, or limit, how individual humans become male, female, trans or otherwise. This is not argue that it is possible to smooth out inequalities simply by stating that 'it is all a question of process'. To adopt a processual view is not to indulge in the worst excesses of either postmodernism or cultural relativism. What is required is an understanding of the specific and different manners of processes that have been possible, are currently possible, and that could be made possible.

A second important point that can be taken from Whitehead (and Haraway 1991: 173) is that it is not helpful to set up the debate in such a way that it appears that there can be one answer, one solution, to all questions about the reality of being a man, woman, or otherwise. What is required is a focus upon, and an understanding of, the specific instances that create specific concerns; for example, over which public toilet/bathroom individuals may use, which needs to be balanced with matters of feeling either safe or respected. Paying attention to particular concerns, in particular instances, is likely to be more productive than aiming to provide a universal solution.

A generous reading of de Beauvoir and Irigaray makes it clear that the lives and lived experiences of many women and transgendered individuals demonstrate that the processes for becoming such subjects can be arduous. Thinking and acting differently is not easy. Nevertheless:

it is better, too, to remain living persons: men and women, than to become neutral, abstract, artificial individuals, members of a social machine which functions more or less efficiently [. . .] and in which identity and relationships between persons come second to the rule of money and to the arbitrary authority of certain decisions. (Irigaray 2000a: 155)

Irigaray's work is contentious, provocative and fruitful. It would have been possible to edit the phrase 'men and women' from this quotation or to replace it with 'persons'. Retaining this phrase is a reminder of the trenchant status of words, ideas and events surrounding questions of 'sex' and 'gender'. What can be taken from Irigaray's account is the need to recognise that language and the world are tied up with what it means to be and live as a person. Such persons have differences that need to be recognised. The danger is that of attempting to iron out difference at the level of language alone, thereby creating a falsely neutral society, submitting ourselves to a societal machine that is concerned not with us but with efficiency. In such a world we are not fully persons; we come second to the rule of money and the arbitrary decisions of others. This sounds like capitalism. It is time to turn to this.